The Capital Trap

Student sheet · Lycée général et technologique · Seconde and Première · tronc commun B1 / B1+

Official page: https://itineraires-destinations.fr/the-capital-trap/

Seven lessons of 55 minutes, timed for 52 minutes, plus a written and an oral assessment.

Name: _____ Class: _____

Key question: **Is the biggest city always the capital?**

Write on this sheet, or in your notebook. Answer keys are always visible on the official pages. Make your own bristol flashcards: the useful work is the cards you make yourself. City populations on the website are approximate and are given so that you can compare places.

Lesson 1. Why geography matters

Why did the first big American cities grow near water?

What mistake did Inès make? Who explained it to her?

Explain Inès's sentence: "A map is not a list of names." Do you agree?

Eight words to learn: to stretch · goods · a harbour · the mouth of a river · a canal · a pioneer · to turn red · a host family.

Lesson 2. Discovering the map

On the map I can find:

Two oceans and one gulf: _____

Two neighbouring countries: _____

Three rivers: _____

The Great Lakes: yes / not yet. Alaska and Hawaii: _____

Exercise 1. Complete: The Mississippi _____ into the Gulf of Mexico. Texas _____ Mexico. Alaska is _____ from Russia by the Bering Strait. Niagara Falls are located _____ New York State and Canada. Hawaii is a group of _____ in the Pacific Ocean. Denver is _____, far from the coast.

Exercise 2. *In the north of* or *north of*? Canada is _____ the USA. Chicago is _____ Illinois. Mexico is _____ Texas. Miami is _____ Florida.

Written record:

© 2026 Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac · CC BY-NC-SA 4.0

Lesson 3. Big cities vs capitals

Model: Houston is bigger than Austin, but Austin is the capital of Texas.

Los Angeles / Sacramento:

New York City / Albany:

Chicago / Springfield:

USA records: Montpelier is _____ state capital. Alaska is _____ state. Key West is _____ city in the continental USA. New York City is _____ city in the USA. Juneau is _____ capital to reach.

Pronunciation to practise: Illinois, Arkansas, Houston, Albany, Juneau.

Five pairs I will remember (The capital of X is Y):

Lesson 4. Map detective

Juneau: can you drive from Seattle? Why or why not?

Would you like to live in Juneau? Why or why not?

Names and origins (write the language, and the meaning if you know it):

Detroit: _____ Baton Rouge: _____

Los Angeles: _____ Chicago: _____

Mississippi: _____ Juneau: _____

Lesson 5. Guess the city

A city I described or guessed, and the clues I used:

© 2026 Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac · CC BY-NC-SA 4.0

Exercise 3. Compare two cities (three sentences):

Lesson 6. The Capital Trap game

The three most surprising pairs I met today:

One exception (a city that is both the capital and the biggest city):

Lesson 7. Planning a road trip

What's this? Route 66 links _____ to _____. It crosses eight states. The Springfield trap: which Springfield is a capital?

Lucas's trip: fly, visit, take, drive, eat, listen, swim. Write the preterite forms:

My road-trip card: _____

My itinerary in the past:

My postcard (written assessment)

80 to 100 words, to an English-speaking friend. At least three cities, including one capital. Use the past tense. Compare two places. Give one surprising fact about a city or its name.

Dear _____ ,

© 2026 Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac · CC BY-NC-SA 4.0

Best wishes,

Oral checklist

To get a good mark, I must:

- talk for 2 minutes about my road trip;
- name at least 4 cities and 2 capitals;
- use 4 geography words;
- compare two places;
- pronounce the city names correctly;
- answer the teacher’s questions with full sentences.

Keywords only (no written-out sentences) during the 10 minutes of preparation:

© 2026 Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac · CC BY-NC-SA 4.0 · Official page: https://itineraires-destinations.fr/the-capital-trap/

© 2026 Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac · CC BY-NC-SA 4.0